

Qualities of a High-Performing Case Manager



For the past year, the State Employment Leadership Network has been hosting a series of online events about the role case managers can play in improving employment outcomes for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD).

The role of the case manager/support coordinator is changing and becoming more complex. Case management requires knowledge and expertise in many areas, and community-based employment is just one of them.

An effective case manager/services/supports coordinator must demonstrate new competencies to meet community-based employment outcomes. The session on December 2, 2014 emphasized the importance of earning income through work and understanding the impact of working on public benefits. See the attached word doc. You may view the recording and materials, as well as past sessions, at:

www.selnmembers.org/events/casemanagement

Key takeaways

Today's case managers and service/support coordinators:

- ❖ Explain that there are various work rules and incentives to help people try and work while protecting their benefits. These rules are complicated, but before people can make a decision about working, they need to understand the big picture.
- ❖ Make sure clients see the potential monetary benefits of employment, which can be a path to long-term financial well-being.
- ❖ Convey the message that work has value beyond a paycheck. A job increases autonomy and choice, improves self-esteem, and promotes skills development. Working also facilitates social connections.
- ❖ Understand that earnings and benefits are not an either/or choice. Articulate the ways individuals can generally maintain necessary benefits while they are adjusting to working and earning a paycheck.
- ❖ Identify some potential work incentive opportunities that could fit the individual's needs.
- ❖ Remain honest and transparent. You don't need to have all the answers, and you shouldn't make guarantees. But reassure the person that you can connect them to resources that will help them make informed decisions about working.
- ❖ Provide individuals and families with a clear and consistent message about the importance of work. While earned income from work may have an impact on public benefits, it is important to realize the potential for the combination of the two to generate a higher total monthly income. The only path out of poverty and toward financial well-being is through employment. A life surviving on benefits means the person will never get ahead—they'll just get by.
- ❖ Build awareness of and a relationship to local benefits specialists, ideally certified work incentive coordinators/specialists.
- ❖ Know that aspects of benefits management vary by state, and people moving from out of state will need assistance ensuring everything is in order.
- ❖ Understand how benefits may fluctuate over time, based on earnings and other circumstances. Benefits specialists can help the individual determine when to seek reinstatement, when to reapply, and how changes in income or other status impact benefits and adjustments that need to be made.

Terms to be familiar with:

❖ **PASS (Plan for Achieving Self Support)**

www.ssa.gov/disabilityresearch/wi/pass.htm

Plan for Achieving Self Support is an earned income and resource exclusion that allows a person who is disabled or blind to set aside income and/or resources to reach an occupational goal. (Applies to SSI).

❖ **IRWE (Impairment Related Work Expense)**

www.ssa.gov/ssi/spotlights/spot-work-expenses.htm

Impairment Related Work Expenses allow an individual to deduct certain work-related items and services that are needed to enable the beneficiary to work. The cost of expenses must be paid out of pocket with the income earned, not paid by some other agency providing services. (Applies to SSDI and SSI).

❖ **SGA (Substantial Gainful Activity)**

www.ssa.gov/redbook/eng/definedisability.htm#a0=1

Substantial Gainful Activity is the performance of paid work in which countable income exceeds SGA per month. This monthly SGA amount will change annually based on the national wage index.

❖ **SSDI (Social Security Disability Insurance)**

www.ssa.gov/planners/disability/

Social Security Disability Insurance is a program under Title II of the Social Security Act. It is a cash benefit program for individuals who have worked and paid into F.I.C.A. (Federal Insured Contribution Act) and who meet the medical eligibility criteria and the SGA Test.

More definitions are available on the Social Security Administration's online glossary:

www.ssa.gov/redbook/eng/glossary.htm

The State Employment Leadership Network (SELN) is a cross-state cooperative venture of state intellectual and developmental disabilities that are committed to improving employment outcomes for adolescents and adults with developmental disabilities. SELN online discussions are chosen based on conversations with individual member states, as well as high profile and critical issues circulating around the country. Summary documents provide an overview of the sessions and highlight the resources available and knowledge required to achieve best practices.

The SELN is a joint program of the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston and the National Association of State Directors of Developmental Disabilities Services.



www.seln.org